

Step 6

Using Effective Communication

Having identified your publics and established objectives for what is to be achieved, and having set into motion the way the organization is preparing to act to achieve those objectives, it is time to turn your attention to how best to communicate. Since strategic communication is carefully planned communication, this is an important step.

Remember what we said earlier about publics and audiences: Publics are groups of people in a relationship with your organization; audiences are people who receive messages. At this stage of the planning process, begin treating your publics as the audiences with whom you are communicating and consider the various elements of effective communication. Who should present the message? What appeals should be made in the message? How should the message be structured? What words should be used? What symbols?

Thousands of public relations and marketing messages bombard people each day—that's more than three different messages every minute of every waking hour—most of them trying to sell something or gain support. Amid all this noise, how can your organization's message stand out? It's not easy, but effective communication can help your message rise above the clamor.

Communication Processes

Several different approaches to communication are used in public relations and related fields. Three particular models are worth particular attention: information, persuasion and dialogue. These align loosely with the classic models of public relations outlined by James Grunig and Todd Hunt (see the Introduction of this book). The information model of communication plays out as press agency and public information. The persuasion model is asymmetric, with a focus on advocacy and influence. Meanwhile, the dialogic model of communication is a symmetric approach that is rooted in relationships. Let's look more closely at each process of communication.

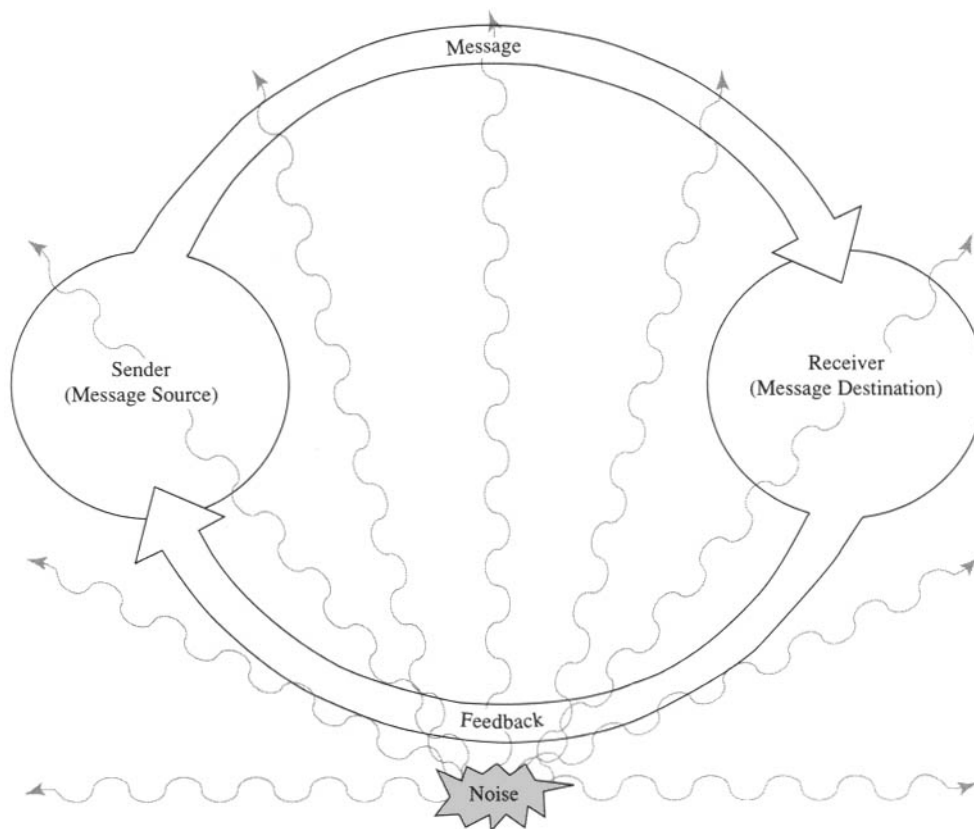
Information

The **information model** of communication focuses on the content and channels of communication. It involves a message sent by a source to a receiver, with ideas encoded and interpreted through symbols (words or images) that are transmitted person to person

or through some technical connection. Harold Lasswell (1948) offered a simple verbal formula of communication: “Who says what to whom with what effect.” We might add “how” and perhaps even “why” to this formula.

Exhibit 6.1 provides a visual model of information-based communication. This model is based on the frequently cited work of Claude Shannon and Warren Weaver (1949) and Norbert Wiener (1954), echoed by David Berlo (1960) and Wilbur Schramm (1971). Shannon and Weaver, scientists with Bell Telephone Laboratories, developed a visual model of what they called the **mathematical theory of communication**. Their approach was linear, with virtually tangible data encoded and transmitted through a

Exhibit 6.1 A Model of Information-Based Communication



In this model of communication, a sender (which can be a person or an organization) encodes a message (using verbal and/or nonverbal symbols) that is sent through a particular channel (such as a speech, a brochure, a phone call, etc.) to a receiver, who decodes (or interprets) the message. The receiver in turn reacts and responds to the message by encoding feedback that is sent back to the original sender. Any communication context also involves noise, which is any interference that limits the ability of the channel to carry a message faithfully from sender to receiver. Such interference can be in the encoding or decoding of the message or in the channels used to transmit the message.

Research Background on Persuasion

Several theories dealing with persuasion are relevant to much public relations and marketing activity. Here are a few of the most common theories.

The **balance theory**, articulated by psychologist Fritz Heider (1946, 1958), is the oldest consistency theory, observing that unbalanced mental stances create tension and force an individual to restore balance. Theodore Newcomb (1953) extended this to groups, calling it the **symmetry theory**. Charles E. Osgood and Percy Tannenbaum's **congruity theory** (1955) added some measurement in attitude. The lesson of these consistency theories for public relations practitioners is that attitude change can be stimulated by information that causes people to realize that two attitudes are in conflict and that the persuasiveness of the source is a major factor to accomplish this.

Social psychologist Leon Festinger's **cognitive dissonance theory** (1957) explained that the more people experience the psychological discomfort of having contradictory attitudes or beliefs, the more likely they

will reduce the discomfort, usually by changing one of their attitudes or beliefs. An important element of this theory is the concept of **selective exposure**, which refers to seeking information that supports a currently held attitude while avoiding information that does not support it.

The **inoculation theory**, proposed by William McGuire and Demetrios Papageorgis (1961), suggested that unchallenged beliefs and attitudes can be swayed with persuasive information, while attitudes that have been tested are more resistant to change. This latter aspect is particularly useful to strategic communicators seeking to create resistance to potentially opposing arguments.

The **social judgment theory**, put forward by Muzafer Sherif and Carl I. Hovland (1961), observed that individuals accept or reject messages to the extent that they perceive the messages as corresponding to their internal anchors (attitudes and beliefs) and as being ego-involved (affecting the person's self-concept).

channel to a receiver. In essence, theirs was a model for monologue, with the source person or organization talking at an audience. Wiener's **cybernetic model of communication** was more circular in design, involving feedback from the receiver to influence the sender. This model is a bit more focused on two-way communication.

Persuasion

Another process of communication, the **persuasion model**, consciously attempts to influence people, using ethical means that enhance a democratic society. Persuasion is an inherent part of social interaction, something people everywhere do. Persuasion is neither deception, which relies on miscommunication, nor is it coercion, which relies on force rather than on communication. Nor is it **propaganda**, which is a debasement of persuasive communication associated with half-truths and hidden agendas.

Persuasion is particularly associated with the advocacy or asymmetric approach to strategic communication, in which an organization presents its point of view in an attempt to convince its publics to give their agreement and support.

The practice of persuasion is widespread and popular. In marketing, for example, most companies try to convince potential consumers to buy the company's products or services. In public relations, organizations try to convince publics to agree with this concept, support that candidate, or follow certain procedures. In public

health and safety campaigns, agencies try to persuade young people to stop smoking, motorists to start wearing seatbelts and middle-aged people to get more exercise. In international relations, governments try to convince counterparts in other countries to adopt democratic practices, and nongovernmental organizations try to influence governments to respect human rights or to eliminate gender, religious or racial discrimination.

Dialogue

The **dialogue model** involves the deeply conscious interaction of two parties in communication. It involves a sincere and competent attempt at mutual understanding, the kind of communication described by existentialist philosopher Martin Buber (1947). It is what Sieberg (1976) called “confirming communication,” which seeks to heal and strengthen relationships: “Confirmation, like existential dialogue, is a mutual experience involving sharing at several levels—sharing of talking, sharing of self, sharing of respect, sharing of trust.”

Dialogue involves four goals useful to public relations:

1. To provide for an information exchange between individuals or groups
2. To help communication partners make responsible and personally acceptable decisions
3. To help revive the original vitality of a relationship
4. To foster a deep relationship that continues to unite communication partners ever more closely

Dialogue also generates two management practices—consensus building and conflict resolution—which help parties consider issues in light of their mutual needs and arrive at solutions that enhance their relationship.

- **Consensus building** is a process of identifying and then preventing or overcoming barriers between people and/or organizations.
- The related concept of **conflict resolution** involves making peace and restoring harmony, often with communication as the primary tool.

Carl Botan (1997) observed the relationship between dialogue and ethics. He noted that dialogic communication is characterized by a relationship in which both parties genuinely care about each other rather than merely seek to fulfill their own needs. This kind of relationship is embodied in the symmetrical model of public relations, in which organizations try to adapt and harmonize with their publics. It elevates publics to an equal footing with the organization itself, allowing either party in the interchange to take the initiative. An example of this would be an equal relationship between corporate management and either an external public such as an activist group or an internal public such as an employee union, in which either side could call meetings, propose agenda topics, conduct research, launch a communication program and so on. Botan also noted

that advances in communication technology have made it easier for organizations to engage with their publics in a two-way dialogue.

In the practice of strategic communication, there is a role for each type of communication model: information, persuasion and dialogue. Information approaches to communication often focus on the message sender and receiver, while persuasive communication deals with the content of the message. Dialogue, in turn, emphasizes the relationship between the parties in the communication process. Each of these elements is important to public relations, which necessarily deals with the actors in the communication process, the messages shared between them, and their relationship.

Rhetorical Tradition

The use of communication to influence ideas and actions and to strengthen relationships is a basic element of human society. History has handed down to us some ancient examples of the art of effective communication. Much of it comes from the dawn of Western civilization in the lands encircling the Mediterranean Sea. Two of the oldest-known pieces of literature, the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*, both ascribed to the Greek poet Homer about 2,800 years ago, feature several examples of effective persuasive speeches, such as Odysseus' discussion with the Cyclops about why the monster should not eat him.

About 300 years later, Corax of Syracuse wrote a handbook on **rhetoric**, the art of using words effectively in speaking and writing for the purpose of influencing, persuading, or entertaining. Basically, rhetoric is persuasive communication. Corax noted the relationship between certainty and probability: While physical evidence can prove something true and thus beyond argument, verbal evidence can show only greater or lesser probabilities that something is true.

In Athens, Socrates and his student Plato criticized rhetoric as verbal maneuvering that could make right seem wrong and important appear unimportant. They called for a grounding in truth and taught some of the skills associated with ethical communication, such as logical organization of ideas.

The first person known to have studied persuasive communication systematically was one of Plato's students, Aristotle, who became the court educator to Alexander the Great. Twenty-five centuries ago, Aristotle identified three central elements of rhetoric that today remain as cornerstones of persuasive communication: ethos, logos and pathos. Following the principle of "don't mess with success," *Strategic Planning for Public Relations* uses these elements as the framework for developing a strategic and effective public relations and marketing communication message. Each will be discussed in detail shortly.

From the Greek foundation, the study of communication passed over to classical Rome, where Cicero organized rhetoric into five principles (roughly argumentation, organization, style, delivery and memorization). Quintillian wrote on the education of communicators, advising that they were about more than simply persuasion; they also were in the business of informing, motivating and inspiring.

During the Middle Ages, the Saxon theologian Alcuin, teacher and advisor to the Emperor Charlemagne, reinterpreted Roman rhetoric and applied it to practical areas such as public policy, legal and judicial proceedings, and the placement of blame or praise.

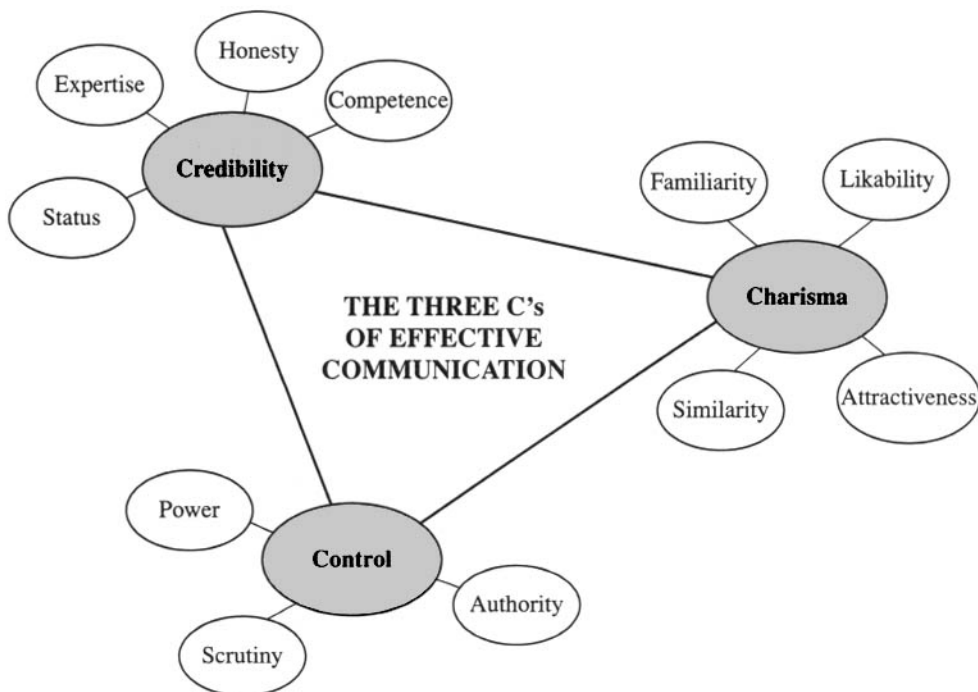
Rhetoric also influenced the field of religion and vice versa. Augustine of Hippo, a Christian bishop in Roman Africa, became one of the most influential figures in persuasive communication with his study, teaching and personal examples dealing with preaching. Later the Italian philosopher-monk Thomas Aquinas applied Aristotelian principles of ethos, logos and pathos to the understanding and explanation of religious belief.

More contemporary figures in the evolution of our understanding of communication include the English philosopher Francis Bacon, credited with formulating the scientific method; American language theorist Kenneth Burke, who studied the nature and power of symbols in human interaction; language critic Richard Weaver, who dealt with the cultural role of persuasion; and Belgian philosopher Chaim Perelman, who analyzed how communicators can gain “the adherence of minds.”

Ethos: Convincing Communicators

Ethos is communication effectiveness based on the character of the speaker and on the common ground shared by speakers and audiences. Years of research by social scientists have produced a snapshot of an effective message source. This is a person or an organization perceived by an audience as being credible, having charisma and exercising some kind of control—what we might call the “Three C’s” of an effective communicator. These are presented visually in Exhibit 6.2. Individually, each of these perceptions is a

Exhibit 6.2 The Three C’s of Effective Communication



powerful tool for the practitioner; in combination, they create a compelling factor in effective communication.

It is important to note that each of these elements is based on the audience's perception of the speaker. Aristotle observed that reputation precedes the speaker, setting the stage for the audience to accept or reject the speaker's message. Even before the speaker presents a message, the audience makes a judgment based on the speaker's prestige and prominence. Precisely because reputation has such a direct and predictable impact on their ability to influence their publics, organizations pay much attention to what people know and think about them.

Let's look at the Three C's in detail.

Credibility

A source who has credibility—the power to inspire belief—is one who demonstrates the qualities of expertise, status, competence and honesty.

Expertise. The most important factor in making a message source effective is **expertise**, which means that the source knows what he or she is talking about.

Status. Related to expertise is **status**, but this rests more with the audience's deference to the social position or prestige of a message source.

Competence. Another related concept is **competence**, the ability to remain calm under pressure and to be clear and dynamic in presenting the message to others, especially those who may not share the same knowledge or loyalties.

Honesty. Finally, **honesty** means that the source is willing to provide full and accurate information, is operating without bias, and thus is worthy of trust.

Credibility is tremendously important to persuasion. Though we might wish it were different, being a good speaker or writer is more effective than having good physical evidence. Sources perceived as being highly credible are believed on their own merits and whatever evidence they present has little added value. Even audiences that don't understand the issues will accept their messages, just because the sources are believable.

Highly credible sources also can appeal to fear and use intense or opinionated language that would be counterproductive coming from sources with lesser credibility. For example, it was his high credibility that allowed President Ronald Reagan to call the Soviet Union "an evil empire" and be effective in such extreme speech. When President George Bush revived the idea in reference to an "axis of evil" encompassing Iraq, Iran and North Korea, his credibility was lower and the phrase was criticized and belittled. As a result of the criticism, the president didn't use the phrase again in a public speech.

As part of the process of strategic planning, you can enhance source credibility by reinforcing each of these characteristics. Remember that perception is the key: The source's expertise and honesty must be apparent to the audience. Some campaigns have faltered because the audience didn't realize the source was an expert or because the source didn't appear trustworthy.

Perceived expertise can be intensified by using a message source who has experience, knowledge, intelligence, occupational or professional background or the wisdom that comes with age. Likewise, perceived status is enhanced by the use of message sources who have social status and prestige. Of course, both of these must be relevant to the topic being addressed—a physician may be very credible on the issue of health but not particularly so on a political topic. Expertise and status can be borrowed from recognized experts by quoting them.

Communication competence is obviously a matter of perception. The audience perceives (or not) that the speaker is calm, clear and able to communicate. Perceived competence can be enhanced by two elements associated with effective presentations. One element is physical stature, which includes being tall, sitting or standing erect, maintaining eye contact and having facial composure. The other element that enhances competence is vocal quality, which involves enunciating clearly, initiating communication, speaking with conviction and authority, exuding energy and enthusiasm, and avoiding language fillers such as “um” and “uh.” Two kinds of skill builders—coaching in public speaking and training for media interviews—can help a speaker strategically develop vocal emphasis, convincing gestures and other aspects of communication competence.

Like the other characteristics of credibility, perceived honesty can be enhanced to help a source appear more trustworthy by emphasizing the objectivity, integrity and neutrality with which the source approaches the subject. Message sources who advocate positions contrary to their personal interests or who take an unexpected position have a special credibility. For example, a physician who recommends herbal medicine will be particularly believable because the health-care establishment traditionally has ignored, even scorned, the medicinal value of herbs. Honesty also is enhanced when the message source shows a consistency between past and present, and between words and deeds.

Credibility and News Sources

A survey of 545 Americans by Burson-Marsteller Public Relations (1998) probed the relative credibility of different types of news sources on an environmental issue, specifically global warming. The researchers identified several hypothetical news sources and asked respondents to rate the credibility of each. Here are the credibility levels reported:

- 53% Professor of atmospheric science at a well-known university
- 43% Government scientists from the National Oceanographic and Atmospheric Administration

- 29% Spokesperson for an environmental group
- 11% Spokesperson for an oil or natural gas company
- 10% Hollywood celebrity active on environmental issues

What's the lesson to be learned from this research? It deals with expertise. Recognized experts without apparent self-interest are the most credible message sources. The public may admire celebrities and may even pay attention to them without being persuaded by the messages they present.

As a side note, if you are presenting a position that differs from one taken by your organization in the past, signal the change and carefully explain not only the new posture but also the reason for the change. Try not to allow yourself to be labeled as inconsistent or as contradictory of past statements. Certainly you may change your mind, but make sure you let your audience know the reason for such a change.

Charisma

The magnetic appeal or personal charm that some message sources enjoy over an audience is called **charisma**, another important element of persuasion. Like credibility, charisma is a matter of perception, and it varies greatly from one person to another and from one public to another.

Charisma has several specific characteristics: familiarity, likability, similarity and attractiveness.

Familiarity. One important aspect of charisma is **familiarity**, the extent to which the audience already knows (or thinks it knows) the message source.

Likability. Charisma also involves **likability**, the extent to which the audience admires what it knows about the source or what it sees and hears when the source begins to communicate. This generally means that the message source is neutral on divisive social and political issues and not associated with controversy or partisanship—unless the audience itself is particularly partisan. The principle of likability may suggest that, for a general and mixed audience, you would avoid using a message source who is closely associated with a particular cultural, ethnic or religious group, because the audience may not like someone closely identified with alien characteristics.

Similarity. Charisma also involves **similarity**, the extent to which the source resembles the audience (or the way in which audience members would like to see themselves). This may be a reflection of audience demographics in terms of age, gender, occupation, ethnicity, religion, culture, shared values or sociopolitical perspectives. Thus the principle of similarity offers a parallel guideline to that of familiarity. You might consider using a message source closely associated with a particular cultural, ethnic or religious group when the audience also is associated with that group. Similarity is particularly important when a communicator is seeking long-term persuasion, less so for short-term objectives. It also is a major factor in enhancing dialogic communication.

Attractiveness. Finally, charisma is affected by the **attractiveness** of the source, which involves the source's physical looks, demeanor, poise and presence, as well as both the clothing worn and the setting in which the source is presented. Note, however, that physical attractiveness and beauty are significantly less important than credibility and other aspects of charisma. Despite the Hollywood emphasis on plenty of sex appeal and glamour, average-looking people can be highly effective message sources. Indeed, speakers who are very good-looking, especially if they flaunt their looks, may have difficulty being perceived as much more than pretty faces and beautiful bodies.

Control

The third component of an effective message source is **control**, which is rooted in a message source's command over the audience and on the perceived willingness to exercise that power.

Power. One of the most important aspects of control is **power**, the raw and recognized ability to dominate and to reward or punish. Guilt appeals (which we will discuss later) often are associated with powerful message sources.

Authority. Control also may be based on a message source's **authority**, which is the right to rule over or direct the actions of another. Authority implies that the audience more or less willingly has granted the right of control and thus will give obedience. Authority often involves a legal or social prerogative. It also can involve moral leverage, such as by summoning the audience to its stated values or calling it to its accepted duty. Both guilt appeals and virtue appeals (which we will discuss later) may be associated with authority figures.

Scrutiny. Finally, the persuasive element of control suggests **scrutiny**, the ability to examine. Someone who is able to investigate you also is able to pronounce your blame, proclaim your innocence and perhaps grant forgiveness.

As with the previous characteristics of an effective source, control must be perceived by the receiver. Keep in mind that perceptions change. The so-called **halo effect** demonstrates that a source perceived as credible, charismatic and/or in control can rely on this reputation. Think of the many situations in which a politician—you supply the name, from either side of the aisle—can do no wrong in the eyes of his or her supporters but can do nothing right in the eyes of those who despise him. The same can be said about some athletes and entertainers who evoke passionate responses of either adoration or condemnation. The halo effect is very useful for the communicator. But halos slip and stars fall, so be careful about where you shine your spotlight.

Identifying Organizational Spokespeople

The elements of credibility, charisma and control can be maximized as part of strategic planning, for example, by selecting an appropriate spokesperson who is likely to appeal to an organization's publics.

Celebrity Spokespersons. Celebrities often are used because they are charismatic and familiar. Entertainers and sports figures frequently are spokespersons for companies and social causes.

Politicians are used less so, because they often have as many foes as they have supporters. Several ex-politicians, however, have found second careers as organizational representatives, such as former New York City Mayor Ed Koch (Weight Watchers) and former senator and presidential candidate Bob Dole (Visa and Pfizer Pharmaceutical).

Sometimes spokespersons actually are likable “spokescharacters,” such as Morris the Cat, Officer McGruff or Budweiser's frogs.

Discretion is needed in identifying celebrity spokespersons. Their fame draws attention to your cause or company, but celebrities aren't yours alone, and endorsements

can bring unwanted attention. A drug-education agency understood this and took great care in selecting a professional sports figure as a spokesperson and board member. After rejecting several athletes, the agency signed a football player who had a consistent reputation and a clean record not only on alcohol but also with respect to both recreational and performance-enhancing drugs.

Some organizations, however, have been humiliated by celebrity spokespersons. Hertz endured great embarrassment during the murder trial of O. J. Simpson, its spokesperson of many years. Pepsi cancelled million-dollar advertising commitments involving Madonna, Michael Jackson and Mike Tyson after embarrassing personal publicity about each. Seagram's dropped Bruce Willis after reports that he had a drinking problem, and the Beef Industry Council dropped Cybill Shepherd after she told a national magazine that one of her beauty secrets is avoiding red meats. When the then-world's fastest runner, Canadian Olympic athlete Ben Johnson, was stripped of his gold medal for using steroids, he also was dropped as spokesperson for companies in the United States, Canada, Japan, Finland and Italy. And the Florida Citrus Commission had a sting of negative publicity over its spokespersons: Anita Bryant, who began a crusade against gay rights; Burt Reynolds, who became embroiled in a bitter divorce; and controversial political commentator Rush Limbaugh, who lasted just one year. After that, the commission kept a lower profile. Currently, because of their legal baggage, people such as Robert Downey Jr., Winona Ryder, Kobe Bryant and Michael Jackson are not positioned to obtain many spokesperson gigs.

Public relations and marketing people selecting celebrity spokespersons generally look for a connection with their key publics. It's not accidental, for example, that Hurley Hayward is the spokesperson for Porsche. Ninety percent of Porsche's customers are men, and most of them are racing fans. Hayward is one of the world's best race-car drivers, the multiple winner of LeMans, Sebring and Daytona. Likewise, it makes sense for people like tennis great John McEnroe and basketball player Karl Malone to be the pitchmen for Rogaine Extra Strength in an ongoing promotional campaign using sports figures who have had positive results with the hair-growth formula. And after newsman Mike Wallace went public with his struggle against depression, the Colorado Behavioral Healthcare Council felt he would be just the famous face to participate in its public service campaign on suicide and depression prevention.

Researchers Alan Miciak and William Shanklin (1994) reported that advertisers look for five characteristics when selecting spokespersons: They must be trustworthy, readily recognizable, affordable, at little risk for negative publicity and appropriately matched with intended audiences. In some cases, the selection of celebrity spokespersons is made easier by scientific research. For example, Performer Q Scores, compiled by Marketing Evaluations, Inc., uses consumer panels to calculate the familiarity and likability of about 1,500 famous personalities each year. Golf icon Tiger Wood currently is among the company's highest-rated celebrities, a fact that helped him land a five-year \$100 million endorsement contract with Nike.

Company Spokespeople. In identifying organizational spokespersons, don't confine yourself to a single individual if more than one would better serve your communication needs with various publics. Your organization must speak with a single voice, but this

may be accomplished effectively with two or more speakers presenting coordinated and complementary messages. The important thing is to make sure that a single, consistent message is being presented in the name of your organization.

Also, give careful thought to who from your organization might be selected as a spokesperson for a particular issue. Don't presume that the CEO is the best person in every case.

There are three good reasons not to use the CEO as organizational spokesperson. First, you don't want to overexpose the boss; save him or her for the big issues. Second, the CEO may not know the level of detail necessary for a news conference or interview; perhaps a project planner, department manager or another hands-on person would be more knowledgeable and credible. Third, the CEO may not have the personality to exhibit in public or especially on camera the calm, credibility, charisma or other characteristics of an effective spokesperson.

Some organizations buffer the CEO by appointing another spokesperson for negative news, saving the CEO for the more positive public and media encounters. In a news conference, the CEO could be put on the spot and expected to indicate what the organization's activity or response might be. Another organizational spokesperson could more easily deflect such forecasts and avoid inappropriate speculation.

Don't presume that the public relations director should automatically become the spokesperson, either. Especially in confrontational or other crisis situations, the director may be busy behind the scenes advising on strategy and message delivery. Also, the media often don't recognize the public relations director as a high-ranking organizational official; instead they see him or her as a mere mouthpiece for the people they really wish to interview. In a 1999 study by the Public Relations Society of America, public relations specialists ranked low in terms of credibility as corporate spokespersons. Most organizations use their public relations directors not as spokespersons but rather as preliminary media contacts, conduits for factual information that doesn't require attribution, or sources for other media background information.

Spokespeople and Ethos. Celebrity or not, speakers should strive to identify with their audiences. One way is to emphasize similar backgrounds, especially when such common ground may not be evident to the audience. For example, a university professor before a group of entering freshmen may recall her first months in college or an affluent politician may explain to a group of inner-city residents his experience of growing up amid poverty, albeit of a rural variety.

Another way for speakers to emphasize similarity is to avoid language that separates them from their audience. A white speaker couldn't use the phrase "you people" before a black audience without emphasizing his differentness and insulting his listeners. Recall the flap when an aide to the mayor of Washington, D.C., used the term "niggardly" correctly but inappropriately for his listener, who assumed the obscure word was a racial slur. Remember that words properly used may not be words properly understood, especially if they are not part of the shared experiences of both the speaker and the audience.

Strategic Planning Example: Identifying Message Sources

In its current efforts to expand enrollment and retention, financial contributions and community support, Upstate will use the following three spokespeople:



Dr. Alexandra Jolin, president of Upstate College

Dr. Jolin will be perceived by most audiences as highly credible because of her position. She is a dynamic speaker who projects an enthusiasm and friendliness that most people appreciate. In addition, she holds various leadership positions not only with the college but within the local community and within the state's higher education establishment.

Michael McMillan, chair of the Upstate College Board of Trustees, Upstate alumnus and prominent business leader in Upstate City

Mr. McMillan will be perceived as a credible source, especially by residents of Upstate City. He has received media training and is articulate and competent in media and other public presentations. He is in a position of leadership.

Inez SantaElana, president of the UC Student Government

Because of her leadership position with the student government, Ms. SantaElana will be perceived as a credible source, especially with current and potential students. She also is a regional celebrity among area high school students who has developed much poise and confidence as a result of her athletic achievements, including state records in speed skating.



In its campaign to increase consumer confidence, Tiny Tykes will use the following two spokespeople:



Michael Beaucheforte, senior vice president for consumer affairs

Mr. Beaucheforte will be perceived as credible because of his expertise within the company and because he was hired specifically to address consumer issues. He is a persuasive speaker with a friendliness that exudes trust and disarms skeptics. (Note that company president Theodore Frankelberger should not be used as a spokesperson in media situations because he becomes very nervous when speaking in public; this nervousness is often perceived as insincerity and evasiveness.)

Mary Margaret O'Sullivan, Tiny Tykes Consumer Advisory Council member

Ms. O'Sullivan is a consumer whose child was stained by the defective toy. She now sits on the Consumer Advisory Council that helped relaunch the product. Because of her personal involvement, Ms. O'Sullivan will be perceived as a trustworthy and expert spokesperson. She is not an accomplished public speaker, but her uneasiness adds to her credibility and charisma.

Strategic Planning Exercise: Identifying Message Sources



Basic Planning Questions

1. Identify several possible spokespersons who could present your message.
2. What is the level of credibility for each possible spokesperson?
3. What is the level of charisma for each?
4. What is the level of control for each?

Expanded Planning Questions

Answer the following items for each possible message source. Then compare your responses to determine the sources best suited for this communication task. An effective message source will have mainly high and positive rankings in each item.

Credibility

1. How expert on this topic is the message source?
2. How well known are his/her credentials to the audience?
 If expertise is high, should the audience be reminded of this?
 If expertise is not known, can the audience be made informed of this?
3. Does the message source enunciate clearly?
4. Does the source speak with dynamism and authority?
5. Does the source speak calmly and reassuringly on this topic?
6. How trustworthy will the source be perceived as being?
7. Can the source speak truthfully and independently about the topic?
8. Does the source have any associations that compete with the organization?
9. Does the source have any associations that are inconsistent with the organization's image?
10. Is the source available to your organization?

Charisma

1. How similar is the source to the audience?
2. How familiar is the audience with the source?
3. How attractive is the source to the audience?
4. Can the source be presented in an attractive setting?

Control

1. Does the source have any moral leverage with this audience?
 2. Does the source have any power over this audience?
 3. Does the source have the willingness to use this power?
 4. Does the source have the ability to investigate this audience?
 5. Does the source have the authority to reward or punish this audience?
 6. Does the source have the authority to blame or forgive this audience?
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Logos: Appealing to Reason

Communication effectiveness based on the rational appeal of the message was known to the ancient Greeks as logos. The conscious attempt to persuade by appealing to logos—logic and reason—is an obvious place to start planning your strategic message. Distill your message and resist the temptation to bombard your audience with every bit of information available to you. Clarify and simplify.

The ancient art of rhetoric is kept current with an expanding research base (see Larson, 2000; Benjamin, 1997; Infante, Rancer, & Womack, 1996; Johnston, 1994; and Ross, 1994). Following is a summary of recommendations and conclusions from many different research studies into effective communication and persuasion.

Proposition

The primary idea in a speech, editorial, advertisement, television program or some other communication vehicle is called a proposition or a claim. Only one proposition should be presented at a time; more than one can confuse the audience and lessen the impact of the message. There are four kinds of propositions: factual, conjecture, value and policy.

- A **factual proposition** states that something exists, based on provable (usually physical) evidence. For example, proof of an increase in urban air pollution may be environmental tests. Factual claims often are linked with communication objectives focused on awareness, which seek to increase attention or build greater understanding.
- A **conjecture proposition** states that something probably exists, based on reasoned conclusion drawn from physical evidence, and asks audiences to agree with the conclusion. An example of this is a conclusion for or against the continuation of affirmative action regulations, in which the conclusion flows logically from the facts as they are presented. Conjecture propositions often relate to communication objectives dealing with acceptance, fostering supportive attitudes.
- A **value proposition** identifies the virtue of something, such as the merits (or folly) of health-care reform. Value claims also relate to objectives dealing with acceptance, which try to increase interest or build positive attitudes.
- A **policy proposition** identifies a new course of action and encourages its adoption, such as advocacy for changing the legal drinking age or for beginning a school dress code. Policy claims often reflect objectives associated with opinion and action.

Whatever the type of proposition, it should be supported with strong arguments and clear proof. Such proof varies from person to person and from group to group. To some, an intelligent argument with understandable data and logical conclusions may prove a point; to others, only the strongest and most consistent of physical data may be considered as proof.

Verbal Evidence

About 2,500 years ago, Corax of Syracuse taught that disputes are settled easily when clear physical evidence shows inarguably the truth or falsity of a claim. That remains true today. Most of the time, however, we are not lucky enough to have such unchallenged hard evidence, so we have to rely on other arguments. This verbal evidence can take several different forms, including analogies, comparisons, examples, statistics and testimonials. Here's a brief look at each.

Analogies. As a type of persuasion technique, **analogies** use familiar situations and allusions to help your audience understand new ideas, specifically by making a comparison between two things that are essentially different but nevertheless strikingly alike in an important aspect. For example, cars double-parked on a congested city street can be analogous to the effect of cholesterol in clogging arteries. Analogies usually are presented as the grammatical forms of similes and metaphors.

Comparisons. By highlighting the characteristics or values related to an issue, **comparisons** can liken it to something else the audience might understand. Make positive comparisons to things the audience already acknowledges and admires, and make negative comparisons to things the audience holds in low esteem. Make comparisons that are easy to understand, such as by showing how one issue, product or theme relates to another. For example, show how a particular tax-reform proposal is more economically feasible than an alternative proposal.

Examples. **Examples** provide conclusions drawn from related instances. Such illustrations can be effective, particularly if the case is recent, reliable and relevant to the situation at hand. Be careful not to argue from far-fetched examples that are easy to dismiss as being not only irrelevant but also deceitful.

Statistics. The use of **statistics** can provide clear and hard-to-dispute facts to make the best case. For example, it is easy to argue the superiority of a particular automobile with statistics dealing with safety, cost and other easily understood data. But be careful, because statistics can be misinterpreted and manipulated, and many people have learned through hard personal experience that comparative statistics are not always as neat and clean as they appear to be. More on this a bit later.

Testimonies and Endorsements. Comments by witnesses and people who have used your organization's product or service are called **testimonies**. Comments by people who espouse an idea your organization supports are called **endorsements**. Both can provide effective verbal evidence. Testimonies can take the form of letters or other statements of support from satisfied customers. Similarly, endorsements and recommendations from celebrities can be persuasive, especially if the celebrity is known to have used the product (such as Bob Dole and Viagra), participated in the service or program (Sarah Ferguson and Weight Watchers) or espoused the idea being presented (celebrity mothers such as Rosie O'Donnell, Whoopi Goldberg, Bette Midler, Reba McEntyre and Susan Sarandon for gun control).

Visual Supporting Evidence

Strong visual presentation can enhance the effectiveness of these writing techniques. Use photographs, charts, graphs and diagrams as visual aids in presenting statistical and technical information. Also think about ways to include demonstrations and performances in your presentation. Consider too the role that computer-based presentations can make.

Avoiding Errors of Logic

As you are preparing your rational message, try to avoid errors in logic. Some common errors result from unfounded presumptions. For example, don't overgeneralize the argument or leap to an **unwarranted conclusion**, which is a deduction that is not supported by evidence. Make sure your facts are indisputable and understood by your audience; building on incorrect or uncertain data will create a case that is easy to refute. Also, be careful not to make a **false assumption**, a conclusion that the audience may not accept, such as by arguing that U.S. schools should adopt a Japanese school calendar on the untested presumption that the audience agrees that the intensity of Japanese education produces better graduates.

Other errors in logic deal with ignoring the issue and instead attacking the person or reacting with an air of pity or disdain. Finally, remember that any appeal to authority or tradition will be effective only if the audience already respects and accepts that authority or tradition.

Misuse of Statistics

The 19th century British prime minister, Benjamin Disraeli, once wrote: "There are three kinds of lies: lies, damned lies and statistics." That captures the feeling of many people, who in the face of the supposed statistical evidence have learned that statistics aren't always to be trusted. Actually, usually inaccurate data can be spotted. The problem lies less with the statistics and more in their interpretation. Often, it's a matter of arriving at a common definition of terms.

Take the simple concept of "average," for example. In general terms, **average** refers to the usual or ordinary instance. But in dealing with statistics, average can be a real sticking point for understanding, because it can mean different things. Consider the following information about 11 university students who share a dorm suite.

- Alan works in the dean's office and earns \$10,000.
- Jere, Jamal and Monika work for the university police and earn \$7,500 each.
- Maria and Tomiko work in the library and earn \$5,000 each.
- Tim, Pat and Lori work in the department office and earn \$4,000 each.
- Sylvia and Juan work with food service and earn \$4,000 each.

What's the average salary? It could be \$5,681 (if you calculate average as the **mean**, total wages divided by the number of wage earners). Or, the average is \$5,000 (if you

use the **median**, the middle number on the list; in this case, Tomiko). Or you can say the average is \$4,000 (if you reference the **mode**, the most common number; that is, the number occurring most frequently). The point is, make sure you are clear in defining your terms.

Often, the problem with statistics is how they are interpreted. Few things in society are more contested and controversial than the issue of abortion, and statistics seem only to muddy the waters. One side says most people support access to abortion services; the other side says most people oppose abortion. Both can't be right, can they? It depends on how you interpret the data. Consider the following survey results, all supposedly accurate statistics.

- A CNN/Gallup Poll in 1999: 16 percent of Americans believe abortion should be legal for any reason and at any time during pregnancy; 55 percent believe it should be legal only to save the mother's life or in cases of rape or incest.
- The Center for the Advancement of Women (a women's advocacy group) in July 2003: 17 percent of Americans would ban abortion; 34 percent would allow it in cases of rape or incest or to protect the mother's health; 21 percent would impose some limitations on its availability; 30 percent would make it generally available on request.
- Fox News Poll in August 2003: 44 percent call themselves pro-life; 44 percent pro-choice; 6 percent not sure.
- Gallup Poll June 2003: 48 percent call themselves pro-choice; 45 percent pro-life. Additionally, 19 percent say abortion should never be legal, 42 percent say it should be legal in only a few situations, 15 percent say it should be legal in most situations, and 21 percent say it should always be legal.

So what do the statistics say? How would you describe public opinion on the issue? The data show a lot of centrist opinions, not a clear-cut mandate on either side, despite the interpretation of the various activist groups.

Here's another example of misleading statistics. Your campus provost's office each year tracks and reports on cases of plagiarism. The current report notes that 150 of the 200 incidents of plagiarism involved the Internet, 75 percent of the cases. This compares with 108 of 180 incidents during the previous year, 60 percent. What can you say about this increase? You could report a 15 percent increase (60 percent compared to 75 percent). Or, you could cite a 67 percent increase (108 cases compared to 180). Both figures are mathematically accurate, but obviously, they leave significantly different impressions. The key to using statistics that do not mislead is to interpret them fairly and honestly, and to be very clear about what the numbers really mean, in this example, whether you are comparing total plagiarism cases or the annual percentage change.

Sometimes, the issue is about how well the statistics seem to reflect the population under study. Accurate use of statistics involves what is included as well as what is left out—a matter of context. Consider the scandal of sexual abuse among Catholic priests.

“A casual observer relying on the mass media would form the overwhelming impression of a Church institution awash in perversion, conspiracy, and criminality,” wrote Philip Jenkins (2003). Early media reports relied on claims by activist and victims’ groups, which counted as many as 10 percent of priests as pedophiles, about 5,000 of the current 53,000 American priests. Yet more reliable statistics paint a different picture. Studies in some of the largest dioceses indicated that about 3 percent of priests had been accused, less than 2 percent with credible evidence. Many of the accusations involved women, men, or adolescent boys, by definition not pedophilia. A 2004 nationwide study found that 4 percent of priests had been accused during the previous 50 years. Compare this to estimates by psychologists that about 3 percent of the male population is linked to child or adolescent sexual abuse. Meanwhile, clergy of other religious groups—Episcopalian and Baptist, Hare Krishna and Orthodox Jews—have been similarly accused of child sexual abuse. The Boy Scouts has reported dismissing hundreds of Scoutmasters for alleged sexual abuse. And an educational activist group reports that up to 5 percent of teachers sexually abuse their students, with more than a third of them keeping their jobs. This is not to minimize the tragedy of sexual abuse but to point out that statistics of doubtful reliability and/or out of context can be misleading or leave unwarranted impressions.

Pathos: Appealing to Sentiment

Human beings are not mere thinking machines. We see in Mr. Spock of the original *Star Trek* series examples of inappropriate responses that are so “logical” they are absurd. As humans, we rely heavily on our feelings, and effective communicators take this into consideration. An important part of the strategy of public relations and marketing communication is to link the message to an emotional appeal, either positive or negative.

Positive Emotional Appeals

Many persuasive appeals seek to generate responses based on a variety of positive emotions. Here is a brief look at positive appeals to love, virtue, humor and sex.

Love Appeals. Love appeals can vary—bittersweet poignancy, family togetherness, nostalgia, pity and compassion, sensitivity, sympathy or any of the many other sides of love. Pleasant images lead consumers not only to remember the persuasive message but also to be more likely to act on the message. For years, Michelin has built a successful advertising campaign around warm images of cute babies sitting in tires, and the verbal cue “so much is riding on . . .” Maxwell House coffee and Hallmark cards also have been successful with this “warm and fuzzy” approach. Fund-raising appeals frequently evoke images of compassion and sympathy.

Virtue Appeals. Appeals based on virtue can evoke any of the various values that society or individuals hold in esteem. These are qualities that most people treasure. Recall how patriotic appeals inspired record levels of volunteerism, blood donations, and

Appealing to Hearts and Minds

Research tells us it is also tremendously important to provide messages that appeal to both the mind and the heart. Three areas of study—two from psychology, one from physiology—shed some light on the question of how we can best frame messages to our audiences.

Psychological Type. The concept of **psychological type** is based on the work of Carl Jung and the application of his theories by the mother–daughter team of Isabel Myers and Catharine Briggs (Myers & Myers, 1980; Myers, 1987) and a host of their disciples. This approach observed that people have different natural preferences in how they gather information, make decisions and act on those decisions. Some people, labeled “thinkers” in Myers–Briggs terminology, tend to rely mainly on logic and data in making decisions. “Feelers,” on the other hand, base their decisions more on sentiment and emotion. Seldom will your publics and audiences be so like-minded as to uniformly prefer one type of message appeal over the other. Thus good strategy calls for the use of both types of messages.

Note that this may not be a natural response for many practitioners, because many of the artistic or creative disciplines—writing, journalism, design, advertising and public relations—tend to attract people who themselves are feelers rather than thinkers. The disciplines more associated with management, such as research and marketing, attract a higher-than-average percentage of thinkers. In either case, it is undependable to rely simply on your personal preferences.

Temperament. The concept of **temperament** is an approach related to personality and natural disposition, associated with psychologists David Keirsey and Marilyn Bates (1984) and their followers. From them we learn of four specific temperaments with different innate preferences regarding organization and creativity.

Left Brain/Right Brain Differences. The working of the human brain and in particular the relationship between the two hemispheres of the brain were explored by Roger Sperry (1985) of the California Institute of Technology. He received a Nobel Prize in 1981 for his pioneering work in the field. Evidence suggests that the left side of the brain is responsible for logical and analytical thought, while the right side controls creativity and imagination. Like psychological type and temperament, hemispheric brain studies suggest that most individuals are stronger in one function and weaker in the other.

These three fields have many common bonds. That’s not surprising for the first two, because Keirsey–Bates is a conscious reworking of the psychological insights of Myers–Briggs. Sperry took a different path that led him through physiology, but he arrived at surprisingly similar patterns. By comparing and blending this research, evidence suggests that some people are innately more deliberate or logical, while others are more spontaneous and imaginative.

Source: Adapted from Smith, R. D. (1993). Psychological type and public relations: Theory, research, and applications. *Journal of Public Relations Research*, 5(3), 177–199.

financial contributions to relief agencies in the wake of the attacks on the World Trade Center and the Pentagon.

- **Justice appeals** deal with fairness, human or civil rights, and with issues of right or wrong.
- **Altruism appeals** focus on generosity, charity, kindness and unselfishness.
- **Loyalty appeals** focus on patriotism and fidelity.
- **Bravery appeals** evoke images of boldness, endurance and courage.

- **Piety appeals** focus on religious faith, spirituality and prayer.
- **Discretion appeals** relate to restraint, moderation, wisdom and self-control.
- **Improvement appeals** focus on progress, social advancement and making the world a better place.
- **Esteem appeals** focus on self-respect, pride, vanity and self-worth.
- **Social acceptance appeals** focus on the importance of peer support—the “everybody’s doing it” theme.

Humor Appeals. Appeals based on humor can be very powerful because comedy and amusement are strong human instincts. Humor is useful in reinforcing existing attitudes and behaviors, but it generally is not very effective in changing them.

Humor can make the speaker more liked by the audience, but seldom does it make the speaker seem more credible. However, the use of humor can reduce the speaker’s likability when audiences perceive the humor as excessive or inappropriate. Additionally, humor tends to get old fast, so its use in public relations and advertising limits the effectiveness of the otherwise valuable practice of repeating messages. Finally, if audiences evaluate the message from an entertainment perspective, they can fail to take it as a serious persuasive message. With these cautions in mind, here are some guidelines on using humor in persuasive communication.

- The humor should complement a clear and consistent message about the organization or the product/service/concept. It should never be used as a substitute for an understandable message.
- The humor should be relevant to the issue and appropriate for the organization. For instance, it is unlikely that a funeral home could effectively use humor in its brochures.
- The humor should be tasteful. The *South Park* phenomenon aside, bathroom and bedroom humor generally are counterproductive for most audiences, as is disparaging humor directed against others, particularly groups of people. Self-deprecating humor can be effective in causing an audience to like a speaker.
- The humor should be funny. This is difficult to achieve, because what is humorous to one person may be droll, too cute, ludicrous or simply unfunny to others. Make sure the humor does not insult people’s intelligence by becoming absurd or pointless. Also, given the choice, prefer the lighthearted and amusing touch over an attempt to present uproarious farce.
- Humor is more effective with dull topics (which need sparking up) than with topics the audience already finds interesting. With interesting topics, humor can detract from the message.

Sex Appeals. Appeals based on sex range from nudity to double entendres to outright shock. These sexual messages can be effective in commanding attention, though audience

demographics affect how that attention is received. But the very pulling power of sex appeals has a built-in problem. Tests show that audiences often remember the sexual content of an advertisement but fail to associate it with the brand being promoted or the sponsor presenting the message.

Likewise, what one demographic group may find appropriate and positive, another may judge unnecessary and negative. For example, men respond to sex appeals more than women do, and younger people more than older audiences.

An even bigger problem with sex-appeal messages is that, for all their high ability to gain attention, they are notoriously weak in leading receivers toward desired action.

One consistent finding from persuasion research is that sex appeal should not be used simply for shock value. It is far more effective when the sexual theme has a legitimate association with the product (such as lingerie, perfume or condoms) or with the cause (such as birth control or responsible sexual behavior).

Negative Emotional Appeals

Some messages invoke responses based on negative emotions, fear and guilt being the most common. A third type of negative appeal, to hatred, has no ethical use for public relations and thus is not worth considering here.

Fear Appeals. Fear appeals, which deal with one of the strongest human emotions, are intended to arouse anxiety or worry among receivers, such as advertising that focuses on the fear of body odor or political messages centered on the alleged disasters that await the public if the opposing candidate is elected.

The key to using fear appeals effectively is to accompany them with a quick fix featuring an easy, reasonable and immediate solution to the problem. Fear appeals to persuade audiences to obtain a one-time vaccination, for example, are more effective than those designed to persuade audiences to floss over a lifetime in the name of dental hygiene.

Beware of too much of a good thing. Moderate fear appeals can be effective, but too much fearful content can make people either avoid the message or take a defiant stance against it. Appeals that present harsh consequences may cause audiences to cope with their fear simply by refusing to consider the message or even by denying the underlying issue.

Another problem with fear appeals is that the balance point between effective and ineffective shifts according to various demographic factors such as age, education and gender. Younger people, for example, have higher point of tolerance for fear appeals, and some research suggests that the effectiveness of stronger fear appeals increases when audience members have high self-esteem and feel immune to pending doom.

Fear appeals sometimes increase levels of awareness without resulting in the desired action. For example, strong fear appeals used in a seat-belt campaign may leave audiences with an awareness of the consequences of not wearing seat belts—perhaps

even with the intention of wearing them—without actually changing the likelihood that they will, indeed, buckle up.

There is a way to make fear appeals more effective: Include in the message a strong how-to approach. For example, don't just deal with the dangers associated with poor nutrition; give several clear and simple examples of how to prepare or order more nutritional meals.

Source and significance also play a role in the effective use of fear appeals. For example, fear appeals are more effective when they come from highly credible sources who are dissimilar to the audience. Often this dissimilarity can be reinforced by symbols, such as clothing a doctor in a lab coat as she presents moderate fear-based information about disease prevention or using someone in a military uniform to speak about threats to national interests and preparation for war. Fear appeals also can be effective when the issue is significant or important to the audience. In a study related to environmental threats—specifically plutonium contamination from a nuclear-weapons plant—Connie Roser and Margaret Thompson (1995) observed that fear appeals can motivate even latent publics to become active, especially to take action against the fear-producing organization.

Aaron Delwiche of Trinity University in San Antonio, Texas, supervises a propaganda Web site (propagandacritic.com) in which he observes the following: “There are four elements to a successful fear appeal: (1) a threat, (2) a specific recommendation about how the audience should behave, (3) audience perception that the recommendation will be effective in addressing the threat, and (4) audience perception that they are capable of performing the recommended behavior.”

Guilt Appeals. Appeals to a personal sense of guilt or shame comprise another negative message strategy, one that is the flip side of the virtue appeal. Consider the “Buy American” theme. Only a fine line separates a positive appeal to patriotism and national pride from one that tries to make people feel guilty. With a positive approach, the message focuses on the common economic good, shared values among citizens and a healthy respect in the quality of American products. With a negative approach, however, the same appeal can elicit a sense of guilt for having bought foreign-made products. Since nobody wants to feel guilty, a typical reaction against guilt appeals is to justify our actions (“Foreign cars are made better”) and to lament the alternative (“American cars just don’t last as long”).

Like fear appeals, the use of guilt strategy can be effective in moderation. In a fund-raising message, for example, a guilt message might try to make readers feel a bit uneasy or apologetic in their relative comfort amid so much misery elsewhere. But try to move guilt appeals away from the negative emotion and toward a positive sentiment such as compassion and justice. If guilt appeals are to be effective, their messages must make people feel part of the solution. “Will you help? Or will you turn the page?” is the kind of modest guilt appeal that can be quite effective. Like the fear appeal, guilt appeals should feature solutions to the problem of conscience that they raise.

Regardless of the type of emotional appeal being made, consider the ethical ramifications. Ask yourself: Is this appeal ethical? Is it the right way to communicate about this issue? Is it fair? Will the organization gain respect by using this approach?

Strategic Planning Example: Determining Message Appeals



Upstate College will combine rational and emotional message appeals in its message.

Rational Appeal

Upstate College will present several appeals:

- A factual proposition based on advantages to students, including current and future academic programs, accreditation, financial aid and alumni and community commitments for internships and mentoring
- A value proposition asserting that this expansion is in the best interests of students and this region of the state

These messages will include statistics, personal endorsements and specific examples of hypothetical students in various academic and economic situations. They also will include visual elements such as photographs, charts and graphs.

Emotional Appeal

UC will present appeals to positive emotions, particularly the virtues of self-improvement and the realization of personal potential. For fund-raising purposes, it will appeal to the virtue of altruism and sharing with students who need an assist in obtaining a college education.



Tiny Tykes will present both rational and emotional message appeals.

Rational Appeal

Tiny Tykes will present several rational propositions:

- A factual proposition based on information about the product redesign
- A value proposition stating a renewed commitment to consumer safety
- A policy proposition asserting the rightness of continuing to use Tiny Tykes products, which have a long history of being responsive to customer concerns

These messages will include physical evidence from outside testing agencies about the safety of Tiny Tykes products, a comparison with similar products by competitors and testimony by consumers and consumer advocacy groups.

Emotional Appeal

Tiny Tykes will present several types of emotional appeals:

- To positive emotions such as child development and family fun
- To negative emotions such as a mild level of fear appeal about using toys not tested and approved by independent agencies

Strategic Planning Exercise: Determining Message Appeals

Basic Planning Questions

1. What is the key message that forms the basis of this public relations or marketing communication program?
2. How does this message use a rational appeal?
3. How does this message use an emotional appeal?



Expanded Planning Questions

1. Does your message include a rational appeal and/or an emotional appeal? (Note: Most persuasive messages provide both kinds of appeals.)

Rational Appeal

1. How does your message make a rational appeal?
2. Does the message feature a factual proposition, a value proposition or a policy proposition?
3. Which of the following provide arguments for your claims: physical evidence, analogy, audience interest, comparison, context, examples, statistics, testimony and endorsements, and/or visual presentation?

Emotional Appeal

1. How does your message make an emotional appeal?
2. Does the message feature an appeal to positive emotions or negative emotions?
3. What is the emotion?

Love Appeal

What kind of love?

Virtue Appeal

What virtue?

Humor Appeal (If you answer “yes” to these questions, the humorous message may be effective)

Will the use of humor make the source more persuasive?

Is the humor relevant to the issue?

Is the humor funny?

Is the humor appropriate for the audience?

Is the humor appropriate for the organization?

Will the humor enhance the message?

Will the humor help meet the objectives?

Sex Appeal (If you answer “yes” to these questions, the sexual message may be effective.)

Will the use of sex appeal make the source more persuasive?

- Is the sex relevant to the issue?
- Is the sex appropriate for the audience?
- Is the sex appropriate for the organization?
- Will the sex help enhance the message?
- Will the sex help meet the objectives?

Fear Appeal (If you answer “yes” to these questions, the fearful message may be effective.)

- Will the use of fear appeal make the source more persuasive?
- Is the fear relevant to the issue?
- Is the fear appropriate for the audience?
- Is the fear appropriate for the organization?
- Does the message include a solution to overcome the fear?
- Will the fear enhance the message?
- Will the fear help meet the objectives?

Guilt Appeal (If you answer “yes” to these questions, the guilt appeal may be effective.)

- Will the use of guilt appeal make the source more persuasive?
- Is the guilt relevant to the issue?
- Is the guilt appropriate for the audience?
- Is the guilt appropriate for the organization?
- Does the message include a solution to overcome the guilt?
- Will the guilt enhance the message?
- Will the guilt help meet the objectives?

Verbal and Nonverbal Communication

Both kinds of appeals, logical and emotional, can be communicated either verbally or nonverbally. Let’s look at both verbal and nonverbal communication as they apply to public relations, marketing and related disciplines.

Verbal Communication

Verbal communication occurs through written and spoken words. The right words—and the right use of those words—can effectively present your organization’s message to its publics. Several verbal factors combine to create an effective message, among them structure, clarity, saliency, power words, product and program names, strong quotes, and both ethical and legal language. Here is a closer look at each of these.

Message Structure. The structure of the message and the relationship between the arrangement of the message and its effectiveness have been subjects of much research.

Several particular elements have been researched: giving one side or two sides of an argument, the order of presentation, and the value of drawing conclusions or making recommendations.

Should you present only your point of view, or should you address the opposition's argument? The research suggests that it depends upon the audience and the circumstances.

One-sided arguments present the organization's or speaker's point of view but not the opposing views. This kind of argument is useful in reinforcing opinions, because one-sided arguments don't confuse the audience with alternatives, but one-sided arguments are less effective in changing opinions. Four conditions warrant the use of one-sided arguments: (1) The audience is friendly and already agrees with your position, (2) its members have low educational levels, (3) your position will be the only one presented, or (4) the objective is immediate opinion change. Presenting only one side of an argument can cause a temporary attitudinal change, but this is likely to be eliminated if the audience later hears a convincing argument from the other side.

Two-sided arguments present both the pros and the cons of an issue, though not necessarily objectively. They usually criticize the opposition's position. Two-sided arguments are necessary with better-educated audiences, with audiences that are undecided on an issue, and with audiences aware that another side of the issue exists. Such arguments can improve your ability to persuade these audiences because you will be perceived as being more honest and more respectful of the audience's intelligence. If you present both sides of the argument, you have a better chance of achieving a greater attitude change that will remain high when the audience hears the opposing argument from another source.

Order of presentation refers to the way the argument unfolds. Should you present arguments in order of least to most important or vice versa? It generally doesn't seem to matter, as long as you are consistent. However, in developing your persuasive message, you may have reason to choose one form over the other. For example, do you think your audience will be more attentive at the beginning of the message? If so, then use your strongest arguments there.

The final word is also very important, and plenty of research points out that the last-made point is the one best remembered. This is especially true with less-sophisticated audiences, as well as for audiences that are less knowledgeable or less personally involved in the issue. Comic Paula Poundstone said it well in a stand-up routine referring to a political campaign that dealt with the economy: "I don't know anything about the economy. I tend to agree with the last guy who spoke."

In your two-sided arguments, sandwich the information. That is, first present your side—the first argument often is perceived as the strongest. Then present and refute the opposing arguments. Finally restate your position, because of the power of the last word.

Drawing conclusions—that is, presenting the evidence and then explicitly telling the audience how to interpret it—has been the subject of much research. To date, most of the findings suggest that making a recommendation or drawing a conclusion usually is more effective than leaving it to the audience to draw its own conclusion. However, some evidence suggests that if audience members, especially educated ones, do draw their own conclusion, both the conclusion and the attitude on which it rests are more resistant to change than if the conclusion is presented by the

Barriers to Effective Communication

Several factors can limit the effectiveness of communication. Each of these is a type of “noise” within the communication process. By knowing what they are, communication planners may be able to eliminate these noise types or at least minimize their impact. Here are some of the common barriers:

- **Physical noise**, such as ineffective communication channels that do not transmit the message from sender to receiver or distracting sounds within the communication process that interfere with the receiver’s reception of the message
- **Psychological noise**, such as emotional distractions by the receiver
- **Semantic noise**, such as the use of jargon that is not understood by the receiver or other

language that carries different meaning for the sender and the receiver, often because of different backgrounds and experiences

- **Demographic noise**, such as differences between sender and receiver in terms of age, ethnicity, social status and so on

With all the barriers that can interfere with effective communication, it’s a wonder people and organizations are able to communicate at all. But the noise can be turned down and the barriers overcome. Senders who understand the potential communication pitfalls can find ways to avoid them; receivers can be particularly attentive to the message and engage in active listening to overcome communication noise.

source. Some studies have indicated that, when the purpose of a message is to reduce criticism or opposition, it may be better not to draw conclusions for the audience. However, can you risk not having the audience draw the “right” conclusion?

Reiteration is the final area to consider for effective message structure. **Reiteration** refers to internal repetition of the main ideas within a persuasive message. This is not the kind of redundancy that involves superfluous words, such as “puppy dog,” “totally destroyed” or “small village.” Rather, reiteration means presenting the same message in different forms, with different words and different examples, each reinforcing the other. For example, an effective fund-raising letter will ask for a donation frequently throughout the letter, each time making the request with different words and phrases and perhaps based on different types of appeals. Such internal repetition can make messages more memorable and, over time, more acceptable.

Reiteration often means using synonyms, different words with similar meanings, as a way of restating the main point. Another technique is to develop parallel structure within sentences and paragraphs to make your information easier to recognize and remember. For example, use a B list: “Be alert. Be prepared. Be resourceful.” Alliteration, using words that have the same beginning sounds, is another memory enhancer.

Clarity. Clarity helps the audience quickly and easily understand your message. To accomplish this, use words precisely, with an eye to their exact and commonly understood meaning. Use simple language—*try* instead of *endeavor*, *use* rather than *utilize*, *say* instead of *articulate*. Avoid jargon unless the language is shared by your listeners,

Persuasive Arguments

A classic pattern for persuasive arguments comes from Hugh Rank (1976), a researcher with the National Council of Teachers of English who outlined a model that considered both positive and negative arguments.

In what has become known as **Rank's model of persuasion**, he observed that persuaders generally choose between two different strategies when comparing their own and their opponent's positions. One approach is to magnify both their own good points and their opponents' bad points. The other is to downplay

their own bad points as well as their opponents' good points.

Rank believes that message receivers can make themselves resistant to persuasive manipulation by recognizing the intensifying/downplaying strategies of advertisers and other would-be persuaders and then by downplaying the messages the persuader emphasized and intensifying those that were minimized. Rank's model also can give strategic communicators insight into how they can more effectively present a persuasive argument.

readers or viewers. In all cases, use a vocabulary appropriate to your audience. Consider the differences in language fitting for teens, senior citizens or business executives. Consider also the setting for your verbal message, such as the differences in language appropriate for boardrooms, locker rooms and dining rooms.

The **Fog Index** (also called the **Gunning Readability Formula**) is an easy-to-use tool that helps writers measure the level of reading difficulty for any piece of writing and then adjust the writing according to the skills of their audience. Some computer programs also can calculate grade-level readability measures. In addition to clear writing, communication strategists should ensure that their messages use correct and simple English, avoid redundancies, generally use active voice, and observe the other guidelines for good writing. Consult a good textbook on public relations writing to brush up on your writing skills.

Saliency. In advertising, planners try to articulate the **unique selling proposition**, that special something that their product or service offers that is different from all the

How to Use the Fog Index

1. Select a 100-word passage of writing.
2. Count the number of sentences. If the passage ends within a sentence, estimate a percentage of the final sentence. Round this to a single decimal space.
3. Determine the average sentence length by dividing 100 by the number of sentences in the passage.
4. Count the number of long words in the passage. Long words are those with three or more syllables. But don't count words in which *es*, *er* or *ed* form the third and final syllable, hyphenated words such as *state-of-the-art* or compound words such as *newspaper*.
5. Add the average sentence length and the number of long words (totals from steps 3 and 4).
6. Multiply this total by 0.4. The resulting number indicates the approximate grade level of the passage.

competition. It is a kind of niche statement that positions the product for the intended market segment. We can use the product also in public relations planning. We call it **saliency**, the ability to stand out from the crowd. Specifically, **salient information** is that which speaks directly to the intended public by letting people know just how a product, service or idea will help them.

Power Words. The use of strong language can play a significant role in communication effectiveness. **Power words** is the name for terminology and definitions that are so influential that they often can determine public relations success for a movement or campaign.

Edward Bernays, the public relations pioneer who rooted the profession in social psychology, said he had achieved “semantic tyranny” with his name for the anniversary campaign to commemorate Thomas Edison’s invention of the electric light. Light’s Golden Jubilee was the title Bernays devised, linking three words that he believed guaranteed interest and support.

Bernays’ advice to choose words carefully is particularly valid today, when media are overflowing with messages that compete for attention and interest. Descriptions such as “low-fat,” “environment-friendly” and “Bible-believing,” and labels such as “family values,” “Vietnam veteran,” “right to bear arms” and “tax-and-spend liberal” are terms that have been carefully orchestrated to present a particular emotional connotation. The same gunmen who robbed, raped and mutilated villagers in Central America were called “freedom fighters” by their political supporters and “terrorists” by opponents. Instead of referring to “political prisoners,” Amnesty International uses a more convincing expression, “prisoners of conscience.” The second Bush administration insisted that Afgan fighters caught when the Taliban government was overthrown were “detainees,” a term that allowed the government to circumvent international rules regarding the treatment of political prisoners (which, by definition, the detainees were not).

Rhetorical warfare is associated with some of society’s most divisive issues. For example, “pro-choice” activists generally disavow the label “pro-abortion” foisted upon them by the other side (which calls itself “pro-life,” and which in turn is called “anti-choice” by opponents). One side speaks of a “fetus,” the other side of an “unborn baby”—a differentiation in terminology on which hinges the entire controversy. When obstetrician-gynecologist Barnett Slepian was killed by a sniper in 1998, most initial news reports called him an “abortion doctor,” rhetorically bolstering abortion opponents and ignoring the bulk of his medical practice.

Consider the strategy of language. News media first called the Watergate break-in a “caper,” a minimizing and rather frolicsome term that might have saved President Richard Nixon’s job had the media not switched to a more momentous term, “scandal.” Likewise, consider the strategic value of trying to minimize the controversy of the 2004 Super Bowl halftime show with talk of a mere “wardrobe malfunction.”

Southern border states are dealing with problems associated with what some call “illegal immigrants,” the same people who others call “undocumented workers.” The latter term avoids the stigma of lawbreaking, which is precisely the issue for some people. So definitely consider the strategy of language, but consider, too, your potential role in what *U.S. News and World Report* columnist John Leo calls “compassionate incoherency.”

If rhetorical warfare is part of society's divisiveness, then rhetorical peacemaking can lead to more beneficial relationships when organizations and their publics engage in shared language, and the path of consensus building and conflict resolution is made smoother by sensitivity to the words used to communicate.

Product and Program Names. **Product names** receive much attention in commercial enterprises. The California Prune Board went to court to gain permission to market prunes under the name "diced plums." Exxon changed the name of the tanker *Valdez* to *SeaRiver Mediterranean*. Meanwhile we find luxury automobiles with names such as Imperial, Coupe de Ville and Continental, while sport utility vehicles are named Explorer, Blazer and Pathfinder. If you aren't convinced of the power of names, try thinking up a promotional campaign for the all-wheel-drive Chevrolet Petunia, the luxury Ford Cockroach or the sporty GM Aardvark. Perhaps one reason the New Jersey-based Kiwi Airlines went bankrupt in 1996 was because it was named after a New Zealand bird that couldn't fly.

The naming game can be a lucrative and mutually beneficial endeavor, with sports serving as the primary stage. From the Virginia Slims Legends Tour for professional women's tennis to the Federal Express Orange Bowl to San Francisco's 3COM (formerly Candlestick) Park, companies are spending millions of dollars to keep their names on the tongues of their publics.

Program names in the nonprofit sector traditionally receive less attention than product names. Organizations sometimes attempt to devise memorable acronyms, though these often end up being somewhat less effective than hoped. In the same locality, the acronym CASA might stand for Central American Scientific Association, Council on Alcoholism and Substance Abuse, Christian Associates in South America, Catholic Appeal for Saint Anthony, Center for the Advancement of Saudi Arabia and Coalition to Annex South Alexandria. A title like CASA might look nice on the letterhead, but it doesn't communicate much about an organization.

Be careful that the program name does not deliberately mislead people; serious ethical issues arise from names of front organizations or programs that fail to reflect their partisan or sectarian sponsors.

Strong Quotes. The statements that people make, **quotes**, are an important aspect of verbal communication. Such quotes should be memorable and meaty. Public relations writers should use strong quotes in their news releases, news conference statements, interviews and other occasions for interacting with the media.

Here is an example of a real pithy quote. In 1998 Oliver Stone directed a television special that promoted the theory that TWA Flight 800, which had exploded two years earlier killing all 230 passengers and crew, was downed by a missile. FBI investigators had specifically ruled out that possibility. Consider the passion in this response by James Kallstrom, who headed the FBI investigation: "The real facts are glossed over by the likes of Mr. Stone and others who spend their life bottom-feeding in those small, dark crevices of doubt and hypocrisy."

Wow! That is so much better than a dreary bureaucratic statement such as "The FBI stands by its original report" or "We disagree with Mr. Stone's missile theory." This is a quote with attitude. It both sings and stings.

Another way to be memorable is to use colorful language. Consider the statement by attorney Johnny Cochran who, during O. J. Simpson's criminal trial, rhymed a key message meant not only for the jury but also for the viewing public: "If the glove doesn't fit, you must acquit."

A more formalized kind of quote is a **slogan**, the catch phrase in a communication program. Serving more or less as a battle cry, a slogan can be quite effective, especially during the awareness phase of a strategic communication campaign. But make sure the slogan is relevant. In 1995, Los Angeles County launched the slogan "Together, We're the Best. Los Angeles." But this slogan begs the questions: Who is together? Best at what? On the other hand, state tourism slogans such as "Virginia is for Lovers" and "I ♥ New York" have been quite effective because they are both clear and open to having various interpretations laid upon them.

Many effective slogans are associated with social movements or organizations. They service the purpose of what anthropologists call "symbolic consensus," a rallying cry for supporters. Consider these slogans of long-standing use: "Guns don't kill people; people kill people." "Only you can prevent forest fires." "A mind is a terrible thing to waste."

Closely related to slogans are **service marks**, words and phrases that marketing and public relations people develop to be closely associated with organizations. Examples are the Army's "Be all you can be," Budweiser's "This Bud's for you" and Nike's "Just Do It." These service marks often are registered, much as trademarks are, and corporate lawyers go to great lengths to protect them. Burger King is the only restaurant that can claim to be the "Home of the Whopper" and the *New York Times* is the only paper that can claim to have "All the news that's fit to print."

Ethical Language. Using ethical language is a must for every public relations practitioner. In considering the verbal formulation of your message, pay attention to the implication of language. Certainly you will want to use language with pizzazz. Power words can lead audiences to perceive an image instantly and to take on an immediate mood—"beautiful people," "cutting edge," "right wing," "workaholic." But be careful with the stereotypes on which power words are built and make sure that reality underlies these images.

- **Pretentious language** is words or phrases that imply more than is warranted. Avoid them, because they can mislead readers. Examples of pretentious language are "experienced vehicles" for used cars or "follically impaired" for bald. Such words can have a backlash if they are perceived as either silly or too crafty. Sometimes pretentious language raises confusing questions. For example, if pets are "companion animals," then should pet owners be called "human associates of companion animals"?
- **Doublespeak** is outright dishonest language meant to obscure the real meaning behind the words. Don't use such language. Besides being unethical, it invites the obvious criticism that the organization is trying to hide the facts. Examples of doublespeak include military terms such as calling civilian wartime deaths "collateral damage" or genocide "ethnic cleansing" and

business references to employee layoffs as “downsizing,” “rightsizing,” “employee repositioning,” “workforce readjustment” or “retirement for personal reasons.” Bureaucratic reports have called drunkenness a “nonsober condition” and suicide on a train track “pedestrian involvement.”

Unfortunately, many examples of doublespeak are associated with governmental agencies and officials who, through such language, betray an appalling lack of commitment to the honest communication necessary in a democratic society. For example, the Secret Service under the second Bush administration had local police set up “free speech zones” for protesters far removed from the visiting president or vice president—and the television cameras. Business and other organizational leaders, too, have demonstrated far too much creativity in concocting language that clouds rather than illuminates.

The task for practitioners of strategic communication is to avoid dishonest language for themselves and to counsel their organizations and clients to avoid it as well, not only for ethical reasons but for the practical benefit that honest and clear language provides the best means to communicate effectively and thus to generate understanding and continuing support.

Legal Language. Strategic communicators also are familiar with laws affecting their choice of language, and they respect both the letter and the spirit of such laws.

Defamation is a legal condition to be avoided at all costs. Defamatory language meets a fivefold test: It is (1) false information, (2) published or communicated to a third party, (3) that identifies a person (4) and holds that person up to public hatred, contempt or ridicule (5) while involving some measure of negligence and/or malice on the part of the communicator. Defamation is classified either as **libel**, which is written or broadcast defamation, or **slander**, which is spoken defamation.

A related area of problematic language is information that intrudes on someone’s **privacy**, which is the legal right to be left alone. These language indiscretions generally can be avoided if you pay attention to ethical principles, such as those found in the professional conduct codes of such organizations as the Public Relations Society of America and the Canadian Public Relations Society. Such codes call upon practitioners to adhere to high standards of accuracy, honesty, fairness, truth and concern for the public interest. (See Appendix B: Ethical Standards.)

Nonverbal Communication

Nonverbal communication occurs through actions and cues other than words that carry meaning. Images and ambiance create the most powerful and enduring aspects of communication. For example, when the words say “I’m happy to be here” but the facial expression shows boredom, we tend to believe our eyes. Likewise, corporate spokespersons who use facial or other body language associated with hedging and lying limit their effectiveness in gaining audience trust.

Most communication relies not on mere words but rather on the images, symbols, setting, mood, music, clothing and so on that carry messages. Here is an overview of some of the most common types of nonverbal communication.

Symbols. As visual representations of realities beyond themselves, symbols are among the most effective ways to communicate. Good symbols have a complex and rich psychological impact on people who see and use them. Baby harp seals and red AIDS ribbons have generated widespread public acceptance for the causes associated with them; armbands associated with the Holocaust or classic news photos of the Vietnam War and antiwar protests evoke emotions decades after those events; and personal keepsakes from weddings, proms and special vacations summon up emotions over a lifetime.

Some of the most enduring symbols are rooted in religion (such as the crescent, cross, Star of David and the Madonna figure) and country (for Americans, for example, the Capitol dome, the Statue of Liberty and especially the flag). A nation's flag is more than a piece of cloth; to many people it is the symbol of family, country, patriotism, duty and honor, which many have been willing both to die for or kill for. As such, it has the power to inspire both devotion and disrespect, and much energy has been spent in nations around the world on the issue of the appropriate role the national flag plays in both patriotism and social protest.

Logos. Corporate logos are special kinds of symbols, which visually identify businesses, nonprofit organizations and other groups. Contemporary or traditional? Elegant or casual? Much attention goes into the development of a corporate logo, which needs to present the right image and send the proper message. Consider the promotional value and enduring impact of the Nike swoosh or the Dodge star. For an organizational symbol to be effective, it must be both memorable and appropriate for the organization. It also must be unique to the organization, one reason that much legal energy is spent protecting registered trademarks.

Music. Music has a special symbolic value. Songs such as "Auld Lang Syne," "God Bless America" and "Pomp and Circumstance" have special meanings related to New Year's Eve, patriotic holidays and graduation, respectively. The next time you go to the movies, pay attention to the power of the background music in setting the right mood of romance, happiness, pending doom and so on.

Passions were stirred when Japan's parliament in 1999 approved a law making the traditional "Kimigayo" the official national anthem. The vote over the imperial hymn, Japan's unofficial anthem since before the Second World War, revived bitter memories and renewed the controversy over nationalism and war guilt. Much of the debate centered on schools, particularly on how children should be educated about the war and on the role of national symbols such as the anthem and the flag in school ceremonies.

Language. In some contexts, language itself can be symbolic. Consider the cultural symbolism of Hebrew, Latin, Arabic, Hindi and other languages associated with religious traditions. Consider also how some of the "in" language used by groups of teenagers, for example, has a symbolism for its users that is neither appreciated nor understood—nor meant to be—by outsiders.

Physical Artifacts. Symbolic value is sometimes attached to physical artifacts, such as the gavel used by a presiding judge or the badge worn by a police officer. Over the years, cigarettes have been presented as symbols of independence, youth, rebellion, ruggedness and adventure. Automobiles are presented as symbolic mirrors of the people

who drive them. And it was the symbolic power of the Pentagon and the World Trade Center as icons of America that led terrorists to target those buildings.

Clothing. A particular type of physical artifact, clothing, often takes on symbolic proportions. This is why much attention often is paid to military uniforms, academic attire, religious vestments, ethnic apparel or royal garb, where each design element often has a special meaning. When President George W. Bush wore a Navy flight suit on an aircraft carrier to proclaim the end of the war in Iraq, his choice of clothing got a strong reaction—both pro and con. Minicontroversies sometimes arise over the symbolism of clothing, such as the appropriate dress for nurses. Attention is also given to less formal but nonetheless powerful symbols such as designer clothing or trendy brand-name eyeglasses. For persuasive purposes, a spokesperson might wear clothing related to a particular profession or occupation as a way of suggesting expertise.

People. Even people can function as symbols, especially royalty such as a king or queen, religious figures such as the Dalai Lama or the Pope, and other important and well-known characters. As symbols, they stand as more than human beings; they represent the dignity and prestige of the office they hold. Recent media attention given to scandals involving princes, presidents and prime ministers, however, has weakened the symbolic value of such figures.

Mascots and Promotional Characters. Another kind of symbol is the mascot. From Smokey Bear to the San Diego Chicken, mascots embody much of the spirit of an organization. Meanwhile many companies and organizations also use promotional characters such as Ronald McDonald, the U.S. Postal Service eagle, and the AFLAC duck.

The symbolic significance of such fictional personifications can change. Betty Crocker and Aunt Jemima have gotten younger and more professional looking each decade as their company's customers have changed. Sports teams are under increasing pressure to retire their Native American mascots.

Colors. Colors also can be symbolic or emblematic—green for environmental issues, pink for Owens-Corning fiberglass insulation and so on. But the symbolic value of colors is socially defined, and the Western identification of white for happy occasions such as weddings and black for funerals is not universally shared, something that communicators in international or multicultural settings need to consider.

Setting. The setting or environment also has strong symbolic value, and much meaning can be created by putting a speaker in, say, a cemetery, laboratory or library.

This concludes the Strategy phase of the planning process for public relations and marketing communication. Having completed these steps, which have built on those of the Formative Research phase, you now should have a clear sense of direction for your program. Before going any farther, present your planning thus far to the decision makers, such as your client or boss. Gain the buy-in from the key decision makers in your organization, who must agree with the direction you suggest, with the objectives and with the resulting strategy recommendations.

In the next phase of planning, you will turn your attention to preparing and implementing specific communication tools to carry the strategic message you have just devised.

Strategic Planning Example: Planning Verbal/Nonverbal Communication



Here is an outline of the verbal and nonverbal communication strategies for Upstate College.

Verbal Communication

- One point of view will be presented: Expansion is beneficial for students, the community and the college.
- Conclusion will be drawn: students should consider Upstate College.
- Message clarity will be enhanced by a Fog Index level of 10th grade.
- Messages will include power words such as “benefit to community” and “quality education.”
- Messages will avoid any exaggeration.
- Messages will rely on facts and documentation rather than empty claims.

Nonverbal Communication

- College logo will be featured in messages.
- Upbeat music popular with teens and young adults will be featured in messages.
- College mascot, salamander “Upstate Eddie,” will be featured.



Here is an outline of the verbal and nonverbal communication strategies for Tiny Tykes Toys.

Verbal Communication

- Opposing points of view will be included in messages: Tiny Tykes is committed to toy safety; the company had a problem in the past but has learned from mistakes and now is recommitted to toy safety.
- Conclusion will be drawn: The company now makes high-quality, safe toys and deserves consumer support.
- Message clarity will be enhanced by a Fog Index level of ninth grade.
- Messages will include power words such as “commitment to excellence” and “baby safe.”
- Messages will avoid any exaggeration.
- Messages will rely on facts and documentation rather than empty claims.

Nonverbal Communication

- Messages will be enhanced by happy music.
- Corporate spokespersons will be shown wearing research and professional clothing, reinforcing the message of research and high standards.
- Clinical settings will be used for presentations by corporate spokespersons, reinforcing the message of research and high standards.

Strategic Planning Exercise: Planning Verbal/Nonverbal Communication

Basic Planning Questions



1. How does your message use verbal communication?
2. How does your message use nonverbal communication?
3. How can either be made stronger?

Expanded Planning Questions

A. Verbal Communication

Message Structure

1. Does your message present only one point of view or more than one (opposing point of view? If more than one point of view is presented, is your message sandwiched (stating your argument, noting the opposing argument and finally restating your argument and refuting the opposing argument)?
2. Does your message present a conclusion?
3. Does your message reiterate its main idea?

Clarity

1. Will your publics find your message clear, simple and understandable?
2. What is the education level of your target public?
3. How does this compare with the Fog Index for your written message?

Power Words

1. Have you used powerful language in your message?
2. Does your product/program have a descriptive and memorable name?
3. Does your product/program have a descriptive and memorable slogan?

Ethical Language

1. Does your message use pretentious or exaggerated language?
2. Does your message use dishonest or misleading language?
3. Does your message use defamatory language?
4. How could any of these verbal elements be made stronger?

B. Nonverbal Communication

1. Does the presentation of your message include a symbol, a logo, music, symbolic language, symbolic physical artifacts, symbolic clothing, symbolic people, a mascot, symbolic use of color and/or a symbolic setting?
 2. How could any of these nonverbal elements be made stronger?
-

Consensus Check ✓

Does agreement exist within your organization about the recommended strategies within this phase of the planning process?

If “yes,” proceed to the next section.

If “no,” consider the value and/or possibility of achieving consensus before proceeding.